



Editorial: Council right on Flock

JUN 25, 2026

4:00 AM

Toledo City Council agonized over an easy and obvious decision but finally made the correct choice and renewed the police department contract with Flock Group Inc. for cameras that read and record license plates.

Presented with detailed examples of Flock cameras providing evidence that solved crimes and brought convictions, council said yes to a \$14,000 expenditure to keep the tool both the Toledo Police Department and Lucas County Prosecutor's Office described as crucial.

Given the extremely tight city budget and the cuts to TPD recruitment and elimination of the highly effective ShotSpotter system, Toledo simply cannot do without inexpensive technology that helps solve crime.

A shrinking police force denied tools that work would be evidence of city government failure and signal investors and potential residents another location would be a wiser choice.

Cleveland and Dayton have both banished Flock cameras over concerns about a surveillance state. The issue was raised in Toledo too and four members of council voted against keeping the cameras for that reason.

Councilmen Erin Kramer, Brittany Jones, Theresa Gadus, and Nick Komives would extend a privacy protection in public space where there is no current legal expectation of privacy.

Moreover, the general council concerns about how private companies use data gathered are beyond naive if they own a cell phone or use the internet. The communication device in your pocket or purse provides a private company with precise information on your location. Advertisements shown to you on the internet use knowledge of your location and the interests you've shown in your browsing history provided by your internet service provider.

Many of the Jan. 6 rioters convicted for storming the Capitol were first identified from data provided by their cell phone service.

Being recorded by a Flock camera set up in a specific Toledo location is much less intrusive than the constant monitoring required to provide cell phone service or the detailed history of your internet browsing habits known to both your service provider and your search engine.

Yet the vast majority of adults voluntarily submit to this private company surveillance as a great benefit of modern American life.

The Flock cameras that protect us from crime by helping police solve cases and send law breakers to prison where they no longer endanger the community are also a great benefit.

Communities like Toledo have the common sense to protect community safety rather than play to absurd privacy concerns in public spaces.

First Published June 25, 2026, 4:00 a.m.